2026

MARKETING RESEARCH

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Before the Ad...

Before the creative.

Before the media plan.

Before the campaign.

There was **Research**.



Where does Research come from?

You’re the brand. You need to understand your consumer. Where do you go?





Research Examples

01 Primary Research

Surveys • Interviews • Focus groups • Observation

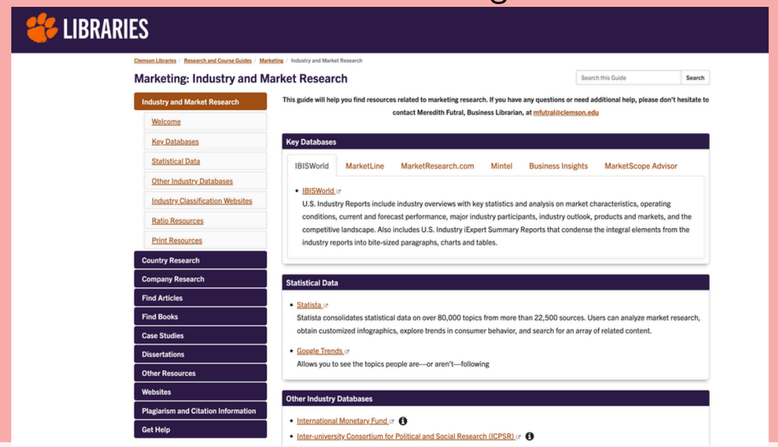
02 Secondary research

Mintel • Statista • IBISWorld • Government data • Industry reports

03 Digital/behavioral research

Social media • Reviews • Search • Purchase/behavioral data

Ex. Social Media Learning Center



https://clemson.libguides.com/marketing

AI is becoming the Research Method.

AI can be the...

MODERATOR → conduct interviews

CODER → process qualitative responses

ANALYST → identify patterns

PREDICTOR → estimate advertising outcomes

RESPONDENT → simulate consumer responses



Spotify x AI Research

Spotify uses machine learning to turn everyday listening behaviors into insights about consumer preferences.



LISTENING HISTORY



SKIPS



PLAYLIST ADDITIONS



ENGAGEMENT

RESEARCH CONNECTION

AI identifies patterns in what consumers actually do, rather than relying only on what they say they prefer.

THE RESEARCH QUESTION:

Can AI encourage listeners to discover podcasts outside their usual habits?

01 AI PREDICTS

Machine learning analyzes listening patterns to identify unfamiliar podcasts a listener might enjoy.

02 SPOTIFY EXPERIMENTS

Researchers use A/B testing to compare existing recommendations with a new AI-driven discovery approach.

03 RESEARCHERS MEASURE

Spotify measures actual listening behavior to determine whether the AI approach improves podcast exploration.

Spotify's Glide Research (2026)

+5.4%
Non-Habitual Podcast Streaming

+14.3%
New-Show Discovery

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Why might observed behavior be more useful to researchers than asking consumers what they like?

What are the limitations of using listening behavior to infer someone's preferences?

What privacy or ethical concerns should marketers consider when using AI to analyze consumer data?

How could Spotify test whether AI-powered recommendations actually improve the customer experience?

Synthetic Data

Artificially generated data designed to reproduce patterns found in real-world data.

Synthetic Respondent

Instead of recruiting an actual consumer to answer every question, researchers can use AI generated respondents intended to simulate consumer responses.

TRADITIONAL

“WHAT DO YOU THINK?”

SYNTHETIC

“BASED ON THIS CONSUMER PROFILE, WHAT WOULD THEY THINK?”

Why Would Researchers Want to Use Synethic Data?

SPEED

Run more tests faster.

SCALE

Analyze or simulate more responses.

COST

Reduce some recruiting/ fieldwork needs.

ITERATION

Test many possibilities quickly.

Can We Actually Trust AI Research?

THE ARTICULATE RESPONDENT PROBLEM

AI can explain why an ad works without necessarily reflecting how a real person feels.

THE VALIDATION PROBLEM

Matching human survey responses doesn't always mean accurately predicting behavior.

AI can produce convincing answers.
But are they accurate?

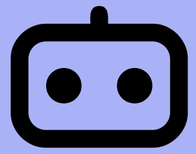
The Kantar Experiment



~5,000

Real People

Actual Survey Responses



GPT-4

Synthetic Responses

AI-generated survey answers

Same demographic profiles. Same questions.

Kantar compared how closely AI-generated responses matched the responses from actual consumers.

What They Found

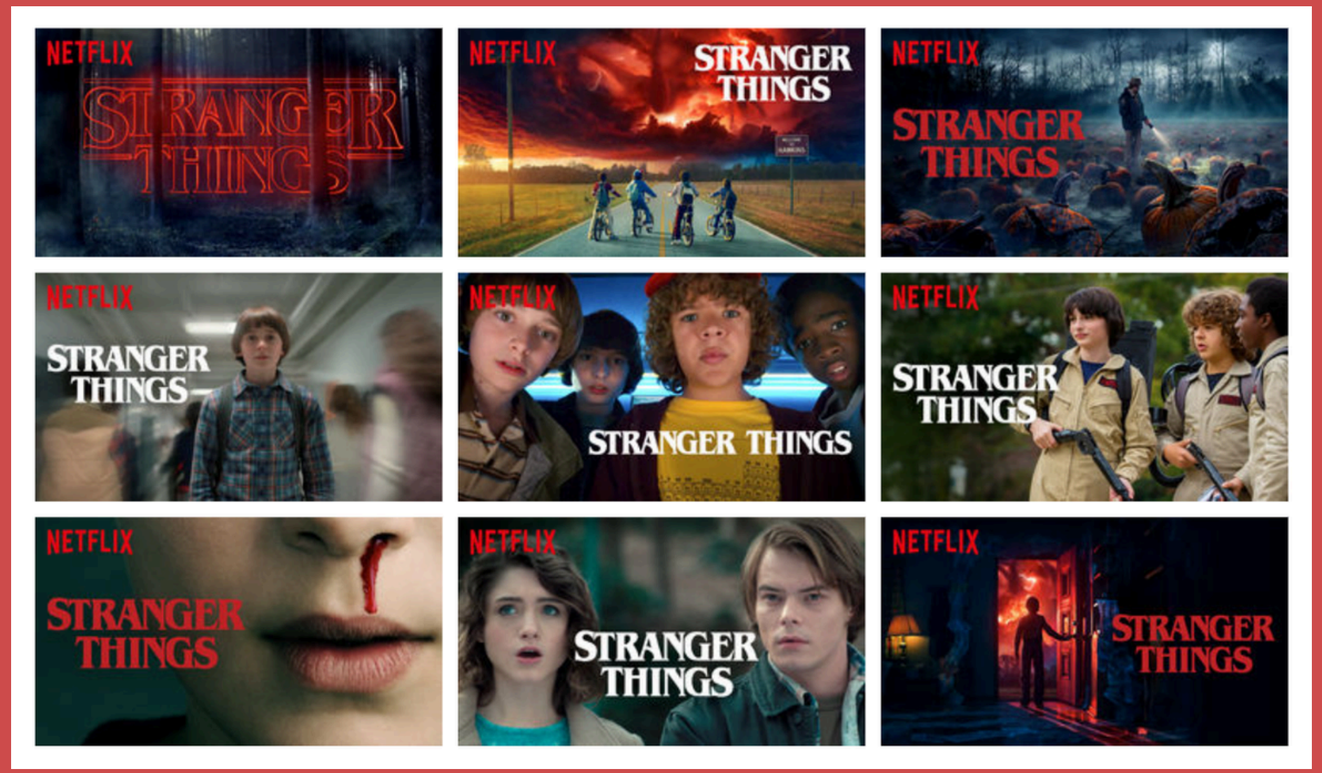
RESEARCH QUESTION	FINDING
PRICE-RELATED QUESTIONS	Synthetic response were similar to human responses.
EMOTIONAL QUESTIONS	Greater differences between AI and human answers.
OVERALL REPONSE PATTERNS	GPT-4 tended to give more positive responses.
CONSUMER SUBGROUPS	AI struggled to reproduce some nuanced differences.

Netflix x AI Research

Which promotional image is most likely to make a particular viewer interested in watching a show?

20-30%

more viewing for certain titles in some artwork A/B tests, according to Netflix's experimentation research.



Netflix x AI Research

Netflix used a machine learning technique called contextual bandits to learn from viewer interactions and select images based on audience characteristics.

Why This Matters:

Netflix isn't asking consumers which poster they think they prefer. It's measuring which artwork actually influences their viewing behavior.



Discussion Questions

If Netflix shows two different people thumbnails for the same movie, is that advertising, marketing research, or both?

Do you think personalized thumbnails influence what you choose to watch, even if the actual movie or tv show hasn't changed?

Would you feel differently about Netflix personalizing its thumbnails if you knew it was based on your viewing history?

Coca-Cola x AI Research

RESEARCH QUESTION: HOW ARE CONSUMERS RESPONDING TO OUR ADVERTISING ACROSS DIFFERENT MARKETS?

Coca-Cola worked with research companies Cint and Delineate to move beyond traditional before-and-after campaign surveys toward ongoing consumer feedback. The system combined actual survey responses with technology-supported research analysis so Coca-Cola's teams could track consumer reactions more continuously.



X AI RESEARCH

HOW IT WORKED:

CONSUMERS PROVIDED FEEDBACK ABOUT THEIR EXPERIENCES WITH THE BRAND AND ITS COMMUNICATIONS. RATHER THAN WAITING UNTIL A CAMPAIGN ENDED, RESEARCHERS COULD COLLECT A CONTINUING STREAM OF INFORMATION TO SUPPORT DECISIONS.



WHY THIS IS INTERESTING:

IT'S A REAL EXAMPLE OF AI-SUPPORTED RESEARCH INFRASTRUCTURE HELPING A RECOGNIZABLE BRAND LEARN FROM ACTUAL CONSUMERS. THE IMPORTANT DISTINCTION IS THAT COCA-COLA WAS NOT REPLACING HUMAN RESPONDENTS WITH SYNTHETIC CONSUMER

Discussion Questions

WOULD YOU RATHER HAVE 1,000 REAL CONSUMERS GIVE YOU FEEDBACK, OR 100,000 AI-GENERATED CONSUMERS? WHY?

IF AI TELLS COCA-COLA THAT CONSUMERS WILL LOVE AN ADVERTISEMENT, SHOULD COCA-COLA TRUST IT?”

IF YOU WERE COCA-COLA, WHAT WOULD YOU WANT TO KNOW FROM CONSUMERS BEFORE LAUNCHING AN AD?

KAHOOT

WOULD YOU TRUST THE DATA?



Chapter 7 presentation

Explore how companies like Netflix, Coca-Cola and Spotify use AI, synthetic respondents and behavioral data to test ads, artwork and...

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